



TPLink-TL-MR3420

Price: ₹5,399



Wireless Routers

With the rising number of people adopting broadband internet in the country, Wi-Fi routers (otherwise uninteresting, mundane boxes) are in great demand and enjoying a revival of sorts after a brief lull in sales the past couple of years. Not only are they useful for giving your PCs and laptops the freedom to access the web without any ethernet cables, but having a wireless router in your home allows internet access to compatible HDTVs, game consoles, NAS boxes, media streamers, tablets and smartphones.

Almost all wireless routers are phasing out support for WEP, the encryption protocol that's no longer safe. Routers featuring Wi-Fi 802.11n, gigabit ethernet ports, operating in single band frequencies are pretty much the staple. However, we're starting to see wireless routers that sport features largely applicable in the near future, but they're still selling at inflated prices compared to others. What are these slightly advanced features? Things like IPv6 support (as IPv4 addresses are set to exhaust next year), dual-band operation (2.4 GHz and 5 GHz support), 3G data card support, multiple USB ports to connect storage devices, media players, etc. are still features present in a select few, expensive routers right now. But with so many different companies trying to outmatch each other, expect prices of such routers to fall in the coming year. However, keep in mind that sporting a myriad of features and delivering maximum performance are two mutually exclusive aspects of a router – one may lead to another in some cases but not for all.

Next year, we look forward to comparing simultaneous dual-band routers and check what sort



TPLink-TL-WR1043ND-04

Price: ₹5,999



Belkin Basic

Price: ₹2,399



DLNA routers

Digital Living Network Alliance or DLNA certified routers go one step closer to achieving true wireless home entertainment nirvana. Plug in a hard drive with media and access it through a DLNA compliant device within the network—could be a HDTV, a PS3 or Xbox 360, or more.



Boost router's signal strength

A simple way to boost your router's signal strength is by changing its operating channel. Use a free Wi-fi scanning tool like inSSIDer to see how many Wi-fi networks exist in your vicinity and what channels they operate on. If the channel's crowded, just access your router's admin interface and switch to a less congested channel.

of transfer speeds they can offer. Since the 5 GHz channel isn't used by many devices, transfer speeds are significantly higher compared to the 2.4 GHz band which is crowded.

Zero1 Winner

TPLink-TL-MR3420

Of all the routers we tested this year, the best performing one definitely was the TPLink TL-MR3420 and it fully deserves our coveted Zero1 Award. It was the best router in terms of total throughput speed tested from three fixed distances, whether it was transferring small 50MB image files or streaming a full-HD 1080p movie. Not only was the TL-MR3420 well-built and mighty in performance, it also had a very good feature set and connectivity options – four LAN ports, a USB port and support for 3G data cards. It didn't have dual-band support but unless you constantly transfer a lot of files between devices, this feature shouldn't matter.

Worthy mentions

A couple of routers that came close to upsetting the winner were the **TPLink TL-WR1043ND** and **Belkin Basic**. On performance, the former managed to score 65 per cent and the latter, 63 per cent, respectively. The TL-WR1043ND looks almost identical to the winner, while the tiny, portable Belkin Basic reinforces the point that very good performance and feature set are mutually exclusive. The Belkin router, in particular, is a great buy for its relatively low price in comparison to the other two TPLink devices.